

Variation Is Natural

Why no process repeats exactly, and the two very different flavors of inconsistency.

Nothing Repeats

Variation is simply another word for inconsistency, and no process produces the exact same result twice. Sign your name ten times and no two signatures match to the millimeter. Even a robotic arm painting a thousand identical cars leaves paint that varies by a fraction of a millimeter on every one. That is variation, the most fundamental truth of this methodology.

Two Flavors

Inconsistency behaves in two ways. Common cause is the natural background noise of the process itself. A commute that takes twenty minutes Tuesday and twenty three Wednesday from a few extra red lights cannot be fixed by driving aggressively, only by redesigning the route. Special cause is an unusual event that throws everything off track, like a tree falling across the highway and turning the drive into two hours.

Why It Matters

The biggest mistake a team can make is confusing the two. Investigating natural background noise wastes time and energy, while ignoring a true special cause means the problem returns. Knowing which flavor you face ensures you fix the process instead of chasing shadows.

Remember this

Common cause is the everyday noise of a process; special cause is an unusual event that throws it off track.